

Using examples, explore the role of more-than-humans as active agents in cultural memory, heritage, and ecological transformation of landscapes. How do these agents challenge dominant narratives of landscape, land use and value?

Traditional views frame landscapes as passive elements shaped by humans. However, more-than-human geographies show us that far from being neutral backdrops, non-human beings are actors as well as humans, and participate in an entangled relationship to create memory, heritage and ecological transformation. Landscape are co-produced by this diversity of actors. (Whatmore, 2006). Plus, Anthropocene landscapes are patchy, filled with various and uneven meanings, stories and ecological changes. (Tsing, 2019). We will explore here how treescapes and wastelands act as agents of memory and change and can belie dominant representations.

Treescapes as holders of memories

Trees, often associated with longevity and stability, are more than passive elements in the landscape. They actively record and transmit memory of past times. Through carving (arborglyphs), humans engrave their presence, emotions and ideas. Trees thus become more-than-human actors that convey heritage.

Arborglyphs are inscriptions (usually dates, names, messages or little drawings) carved on the bark of trees. They are found in many different settings: pilgrimages or shepherding routes, colonial outposts and especially war landscapes. Trees are not static canvas, as they are living being they grow and scar around carving, which merges the memory into the landscape. Hence, trees become non-institutional memorials and resist against erasure by time or a dominant narrative.

For example, In Chycina, in western Poland, carving from Polish, Russian and Ukrainian-written carvings were found on beech trees bark. Trenches were dug by laborers and war prisoners as a part of a larger fortification complex. These carvings are the only witness of these workers' presence and thus act as material memories, preserving histories and narratives that would otherwise be lost. (Kobialka & al., 2015).



Carving on beech bark in Chycina forest

Trees as witnesses of horror

Ponary forest (Lithuania) was one of the sites of mass murders of Jewish people where half of the Lithuanian Jews, and some Roma and Poles were slaughtered, as the density of trees would isolate the events from the world and conceal the mass executions. (Cole, 2014) The forests of these massacres were then left untouched (as a part of the Nazi Nature Act) to hide those memory landscapes from physical and emotional access. Trees were acting as physical and symbolic veils over the victims' graves. The forest was acting as an ambiguous agent, both an ally of the Nazis to conduct their crimes secretly and as an ally of the victims. Survivor Shelya Polishchuk describes nature as protector and savior. (Cole, 2014) As there were few witnesses of these acts and it is not possible to conduct archaeological researches on this site, it is only recently that researchers have been aware of the location of an escape tunnel by conducting a geophysical survey. (Koptiug & Malehmir, 2017)



Ponary forest tunnel

Forest were not only places of atrocities, but also refuges. During the Holocaust, some Jewish survivors were hiding in Ponary and Naliboki forest. They described the forest and wild animals not only as hideaways, but also as active agents of protection and allies, and sometimes anthropomorphized, as the refugees were sometimes feeling a return to animalness due to their new lifestyle change (from a urban lifestyle to life in nature). Trees and animals took there an active role in giving meaning to the landscape and shaping its relationship to humans. Those forest were sites of resistance as well as sites of murders (Cole, 2014). Postwar, they become ambiguous memoryscapes, as they both conceal trauma and emotions and store memories of it.

These forest trees were an active participant in the events and now embody a haunted heritage. The trees simultaneously bear witness and mute the cries of the victims. Contrary to usual memorials which are monumental and often in tidy landscapes, arborglyphs are personal and affective, embedded in living beings and sometimes overlooked or seen as illegitimate. In doing so, trees, as more-than-human agents, challenge human monopoly on memory and decenter them to bring landscape itself into memory-making. More-than-human agencies, here trees, give to the landscape a meaning which goes further from aesthetic or economical by conveying emotional and political messages and and keep the heritage from those who would have been forgotten without the forest.

Trees as smart and connected actors

Finally, trees also carry another type of physical memory: mycorrhizal networks. They are fungi system that connect the trees' roots and allows trees to communicate, remember and learn. They are used by trees to recognize their kins and help them by providing them nutrients of

informations, even through generations. They are the proof that trees are capable of intelligence and being active agents of landscape creation and they keep a record of the past.

Mycorrhizal network



Relational ontologies: ways of viewing the world that treat more-than-human agents as part of the sentient beings

In some cultures, humans and natural elements (animals, plants, the mineral world, water) have a similarity of interiority and a difference of exteriority. This is what Descola calls animism, and this makes communication possible between the beings (Descola, 2013). In another wok on Achuar and Runa people of Amazonia, Descola has shown how they consider non-human beings as sentient and capable of intentionality, thus not strictly separated from humans beings. Communication is then possible by a set of special practices. Achua and Runa people knowledge is acquired and transmitted through embodied, mutual relations with their environment (Kohn, 2019). This view of the forest (their immediate environment) as a community of sentient beings challenges nowadays’ idea of duality between nature and us, and leads to adopt a different view on ecology.

similarity of interiority difference of exteriority ⁷	animism	totemism	similarity of interiority similarity of exteriority
difference of interiority similarity of exteriority	naturalism	analogism	difference of interiority difference of exteriority

Descola’s 4 ontologies

There are actually multiple ways of viewing the world that recognize the agency of more-than-human beings (ex: Ghana African animist cosmologies). It views Earth as a sentient and ancestral being who is an actor in the world and natural elements as kins possessing and transmitting knowledge to humans. It is a relational ontology in which beings are defined by their

relationships to other beings (Ignatov, 2016). In these ontologies, humans' « natural kins » are the ones who transmit them their knowledge, and act as intergenerational memory holders.

This experience co-agency with the forest also exists in our societies. Our relationship to the forest often involves embodied, non-representational intersubjective experiences from our earlier years (Häggström, 2019) which creates special, non-representational memories.

Wastelands inhabitants as agents of capitalistic or socialist heritage and ecological change

While we focused extensively on forests, there are not only the other more-than-human agent to shape landscape. Animals, weed or fungi are actors of memory and transformation, especially in marginalized landscapes (Simard, 2018).

Wastelands are often considered as ruined or dead landscapes at the margins of the post-industrial landscapes, but they are full of life - fungi, weed, mosses and animals. The remnants of a wasteland are charged with history and memories. Indeed, these « *capitalist ruins* » as Tsing call them, where ruins become living landscapes, shaped by non-human agents when humans stopped inhabiting them. For example, the Matsutake mushroom cannot be cultivated by humans and live in wastelands, thus gives a new meaning to these sites. (Tsing, 2015). They challenge the dominant narrative that land need to be profitable, productive or aesthetic to be valuable. For example, more-than-human agents contributed to shape Albanian post-soviet brownfields. (Gkitsa, 2023) or eastern Europe post-soviet collective farms (Tsing, 2019). Wastelands are commonly seen as useless or blank landscapes to develop, but if we understand them as processes, as experience lived and co-produced by more-than-human beings (in a non-representational approach). Sensory, emotional and embodied experience create new forms of memories and attachments to these landscapes (Lorimer, 2008). Weed, « *creatures of disturbance* » (Tsing, 2019) also act as archives of soil contamination, past human activity and changes in local ecological conditions.

Nuclear wastelands as heritage of terror and ecological damages

Nuclear wastelands are places where more-than-human agents record the heritage of global power structures. Nuclear tests were often linked to colonialism, as the sites were commonly colonies or dependencies (Algeria and Polynesia for France, Bikini atoll for the US). Indeed, nuclear landscapes are not blank, and they are the place of the opposition between powerful and terrifying, often secret experiences, and embodied life of often marginalized populations. The everlasting contamination becomes the major component of the landscape. Sometimes, these landscape can have a dual identity - contaminated wasteland and protected natural reserve- such as Hanford site (Washington) which became a wildlife refuge, while keeping the heritage of nuclear tests. Radioactive flora and fauna gave a new meaning to this site and changed its ecology, but it was because the government has decided so. This illustrates the entangled relationship between humans and more-than-humans, and it has as a symbol of reconciliation between past environmental harms and nature (Cram, 2016).

Conclusion

More-than-human geographies try to « *re-animate the missing 'matter' of landscape, focusing attention on bodily involvements in the world in which landscapes are co-fabricated between more-than-human bodies and a lively earth* » 'interrogate *'the human'* as no less a subject of ongoing cofabrication than any other socio-material assemblage » (Whatmore, 2006). Indeed, more-than-human (among whom trees and forests, weed, fungi, post-nuclear life) are active agents of cultural and ecological memory and heritage. They tell us stories of violence, feelings, resilience that often challenge our common perceptions about landscapes as static and purely human-dominated. More-than-humans agency make us reconsider how we value, remember and inhabit the world.

Methodology

My essay adopts a critical approach to cultural landscape, heritage, memories and ecological issues rooted in more-than-human geographies to examine how landscape are coproduced by human and non-human actors. It uses a combination of key texts in more-than-human geography (Whatmore, Tsing), academic literature on specific case study, and course lectures. I critically analyzed the examples with to answer the question.

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Thomas GELGON